

time to play around with 3D text. To create text in Blender, choose the desired location, hit *Spacebar* → *Add* → *Text*, and a sample text should appear. Modify it as you wish, and then hit *Tab* to exit. Text-based commands are found in *Edit Buttons*, as mentioned in Part I of this tutorial. For instance, to add text to a curve, first place a curve, using *Spacebar* → *Add* → *Curve*, and then use *Edit Buttons* to insert *Text* on *Curve*.



Tip: Blender 2.49a and later versions have a keyboard short-cut of *Alt+C* to convert 3D text into a mesh or curve.

Modifiers and nodes

In version 2.49b, the location of modifiers has been altered, to place them in a similar but more feasible location. To add a modifier, select the element you wish to add a modifier to, and then, on the *Edit Buttons* menu, under the *Modifiers* panel, click on *Add Modifier* (see Figure 2).

Nodes, the most recent addition to Blender, are useful for rendering and post-production work. You can consider nodes to be modules or templates; the difference being that they are less user-defined. The implementation of nodes changes quite quickly, so your best bet is to keep an eye on the Blender.org wiki. Since Blender 2.49a, the latest nodes (also see Figure 3) are:

Group	To specify user-defined blocks of nodes
Distort	To change the shape of the image
Matte	To mask off image areas
Converter	To change formats and/or separate colours
Filter	To enhance or blur images
Vector	To change or intensify reflections
Colour	Colour, brightness, contrast, transparency settings
Output	To preview the results
Input	To add an image on the Node Map

That winds up the summary of new Blender features in recent years. Now, let's get to the business end of things. Blender has newly incorporated two terrific concepts, the first one being the ability to create MPEG movies.

Creating a movie

Technically speaking, a movie is an aggregation of short clips or images, combined with sounds and effects. Yes, Blender can help you build one! Blender 2.49b comes with a preset screen for sequence editing. To access it, click the *4-Sequence* option in the top toolbar (see Figure 4). Doing this will make your screen look something like Figure 5. Don't panic!

Now, creating a video basically requires some moving around, metaphorically speaking. First, set up the options in *Render Buttons*, and then press the *Do-Sequence* button. Next, press the *Add* button above the *Buttons* window, to



Figure 1: Ray-tracing in Blender



Figure 2: Adding a modifier

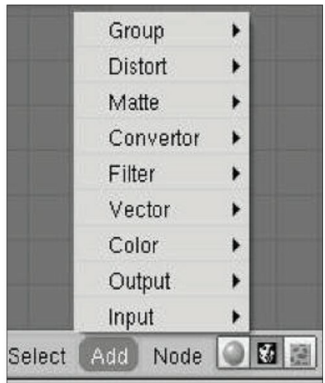


Figure 3: Node window in Blender 2.49b

insert images, audio and movie effects. Insertion of images is simple, but while inserting audio files, be aware that not all formats offer equally good performance. As a general convention, avoid formats like WMA because, more often than not, they are finicky. I prefer using WAV, but note that this considerably increases the size of the output file. For